A Death in Bethany

By Garry Williams

It is night. In the dim light of streetlamps we can see a small living room, cheaply furnished. It is tidy, but very little money went into the place. There is a knocking at the offstage front door. It comes again, louder. Then again, louder.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Experiencing the death of a parent is a traumatic experience for anyone.*
ACTRESS: *For men, though, the death of a father is uniquely and deeply traumatic.*
ACTOR: *Whether or not a father and son are close in life, they are undeniably connected—and this is acutely evident to a man when his father dies.*
ACTRESS: *At that moment, a man realizes how much of his identity has been defined by his father.*
ACTOR: *The powerful emotions and life adjustments that follow Dad's passing catch most men completely off guard.*
ACTRESS: *This is true for Henry– he has lost his wife, his children and tonight his father. How he copes is the focus of . . .*
TOGETHER: *A Death in Bethany by Garry Williams.*

HENRY: *(Offstage)* Roz? Roz, open the door

A woman of twenty-five or so comes out from the wings – or an onstage door – wrapping a robe tightly around her body. She moves silently toward the front door and stands in the darkness.

HENRY: *(Offstage)* Roz, I know you're in there, open the door! *(After a beat, roaring)* You want me through the picture window?

ROZ: Go away, Henry.

HENRY: *(Offstage)* Bullshit. I want to see my kids, Roz. I'm not goin' away till I see my kids. I won't even wake 'em up.

ROZ: You'da woke 'em already if they were here. They're not here.

HENRY: *(Offstage)* Bullshit.

ROZ: They're not, Henry. They're at my mom's. Go to a phone booth and call her, She'll tell you.

HENRY: Yeah, I know what she'd tell me.

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(There is a sadness in Henry's voice; a resignation of sorts that belies the bravado of his words. Consciously or unconsciously, Roz reacts to it.)

ROZ: Go home. Sleep it off, you can see 'em tomorrow.

HENRY: I wanta see 'em now!

ROZ: No, Henry. You're drunk, just go home.

HENRY: I am home. And I'm not drunk. Now, you let me in or I'm comin' through a window. I mean it, Roz. You know I'll do it.

ROZ: I'll call the cops.

HENRY: Weasel and Billy are doin' nights this month. And they'll just tell you to let me in.

(There must be truth to this, because she goes to the door and unlocks it. Henry is a young man, mid-twenties, dressed in factory overalls and steel-toed black shoes. He looks around at the darkened living room)

HENRY: You sleepin'?

ROZ: It's night, isn't it? Yeah I was sleepin'. How come you're not at work?

HENRY: I was. You sure the kids aren't here?

ROZ: If they were here I'd let you see 'em, okay?

HENRY: Why they at your mom's?

ROZ: Hank's been havin' his nightmares again. He thinks he won't have 'em if he's over there.

HENRY: How often's he havin' 'em?

ROZ: They come and go, like before. (Henry sighs)

HENRY: Damn. Damn. Hey, can we turn on some lights here, or what?

ROZ: Henry, I can't be staying up talking, okay, I have to work in the morning.

HENRY: *(turns on a lamp anyway and slumps on the couch).* You got any coffee?

ROZ: I'm not your maid, either.

HENRY: Oh, come on, Roz, gimme a break, willya?

ROZ: You want coffee, you know who can make it for you.

(Henry sags. He puts his face in his hands, then runs them aimlessly through his hair. Then he slumps sideways onto the couch, curling into a loose fetal position.)

HENRY: You still got that blanket in the closet there? The one with the ducks on it?

ROZ: No.

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HENRY: Oh, come on, you know you do.

ROZ: You're not gonna sleep here.

HENRY: I wanta be here when the kids come.

ROZ: In your work clothes on the couch. They'll think you were drunk.

HENRY: No they won't.

ROZ: What else would they think?

HENRY: *(Sitting up, with emphasis)* That I missed them. That I needed to see them. That maybe I'm not such a terrible guy.

ROZ: *(A beat)* They'll think you were drunk.

HENRY: *(Laying back down)* Thanks, Roz. I really needed that.

ROZ: Henry, I'm not kidding, now, get up.

HENRY: You won't even know I'm here. Just go back to bed. I won't come in or nothin', I swear.

ROZ: What'd she do, kick you out?

HENRY: I'm so tired, Roz. I feel like I'm melting somewhere, way down inside.

ROZ: Henry . . .

HENRY: My dad died, Roz.

ROZ: *(A whisper)* What?

HENRY: Heart attack, they think. Just died, right there at the punch press.

ROZ: Oh, God, Henry.

HENRY: They called me on the loud speaker. Told me to get to section four real quick. I knew it as I ran.

ROZ: I'm so sorry.

HENRY: I never saw a dead person before. I mean, just dead, right there in the real world, you know? I mean, I've seen those wax-lookin' bodies in caskets, but I've never seen anyone dead in the real world. And it was my dad. *(Roz kneels tentatively beside him. She reaches a hand out and strokes his hair)* I think somethin' melted inside me, Roz. Somethin' scary and important. I thought it was gonna run all over the floor, like blood or pee or somethin'.

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That it was gonna mess my dad up. He was all clean and dead, you know, and somethin' was gonna come out of me and mess him all up. (Roz keeps stroking his hair, gently and softly as she would a child.) I'll never ask you for nothin' else, Roz, if you'll just let me sleep here and wait for the kids.

ROZ: Henry . . .

HENRY: Please, Roz.

ROZ: *(Quietly)* Henry. Henry, don't. Six months ago. You left me six . . . months ago!

(The primal urgency of her voice seems to Henry in place. Struck by the truth of her words Henry breaks away. Then he sits on a coffee table, his back to the audience. Roz walks around and posts herself right in front of him. She lifts his face roughly and locks eyes with him)

ROZ: I'm a real person, Henry. I am a real person. (Roz hold Henry's gaze a moment longer, then steps back. Speaks quietly) I'm, um . . . I'm gonna go take a shower. You be okay for a minute? (She starts to go but Henry's voice stops her)

HENRY: Hank's nightmares . . . ?

ROZ: Yeah?

HENRY: I'd take 'em away if I could. I'd take 'em on myself.

ROZ: I know. (He reaches out and holds a corner of her robe)

HENRY: I came over here to ask if I could come back.

ROZ: I know.

HENRY: Were you gonna let me?

ROZ: No.

HENRY: Because of Monty?

ROZ: No.

HENRY: Because of Alicia?

ROZ: No.

HENRY: Then why?

ROZ: I don't know. I wanted to hate you and I hadn't started hating you yet. I figured I deserved a while of that. *(He nods. She tries to go but he holds tightly to her robe)*

HENRY: My mom gave herself twenty years of it. You figure it'll take you that long.

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ROZ: I don't know. I'm not your mom.

HENRY: And I'm not my dad. Hell of a way to realize you're not somebody else, look at 'em dead on a floor. I just kept lookin' at him layin' there, sayin', "Can't we do something'? Can't we do somethin'?" And Al Johnson said, "He don't need nothin' now, Henry." And I thought, he never did need nothin'. You know it, Roz? He never needed nothin'. Not me or Johnny or Mitzi or mom or nothin'. Him dead on the floor was no different than him alive standin' at that punch press, 'cause he didn't need nothin' either way. *(Starting to cry)* The son of a bitch has been dead for twenty years. I shoulda known it back then. I shoulda known it when he left home. I spent my whole life tryin' to be a dead man. A dead man who lived across town. *(Now the tears can't be stopped)* Goddammit. Goddammit, I didn't want to do this.

ROZ: It's okay.

HENRY: No, it isn't. I didn't want to do this. *(He stands, wiping madly at the tears, but they keep coming)* I just wanted to see the kids. I just wanted to look at 'em while they were sleepin'. *(Pacing now, looking for something)* I'll get out of here in a minute, I just gotta find my jacket.

ROZ: Stay, Henry.

HENRY: Look, I'm gonna get my jacket and get outta here. I'll see the kids tomorrow.

ROZ: Stay, Henry.

HENRY: Just help me find my jacket.

ROZ: You didn't have one, honey.

HENRY*: (Crying harder)* Oh, God, look at me. This shit's melting inside me and it's gonna get all over the place. It's gonna come out and mess everything up.

ROZ: It's all right.

HENRY: No, it's not. It's comin' out al over the place. Jesus God, let it stay inside me . . . *(She goes to him and holds him)*

ROZ: We'll get in the shower, okay? We'll get in the shower and it can all come out. It can all come out and won't mess up a thing.

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HENRY: I'm scared.

ROZ: I know.

HENRY: I never needed nothin' before.

ROZ: I know.

HENRY: I don't know how to do it.

ROZ: Sure you do, Henry. Sure you do. The kids'll be home tomorrow. The sun'll come up and the kids'll be home.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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